

Power Sharing

Social Science - Class 10

Power Sharing: An Introduction

Power sharing is a system where power is distributed among different organs of government, different levels of government, social groups, and political parties. The idea behind power sharing is to reduce the possibility of conflict and ensure the stability of the political order. This chapter helps us understand why power sharing is desirable and how it is implemented in modern democracies. We will begin our study by examining two contrasting case studies: Belgium and Sri Lanka. These two stories illustrate how different approaches to power sharing can lead to vastly different outcomes.

Belgium is a small country in Europe with a complex ethnic composition. Of its total population, 59

- Power sharing is the distribution of power to prevent concentration in one hand.
- It is crucial for political stability and accommodating diverse social groups.
- Belgium's population is divided mainly between Dutch (59
- The French minority was wealthy, leading to tensions with the Dutch majority.

The Belgian Model of Accommodation

Between 1970 and 1993, the Belgian leaders amended their constitution four times to work out an arrangement that would enable everyone to live together within the same country. The arrangement they worked out is known as the Belgian Model. It is a remarkable and innovative solution to ethnic conflict that successfully prevented civil strife and a possible division of the country. The key features of this model were:

- 1. Equal Representation in the Central Government:** The constitution prescribes that the number of Dutch and French-speaking ministers shall be equal in the central government. No single community can make decisions unilaterally. This ensured that both groups had a say in national policies.
- 2. Decentralization of Power:** Many powers of the central government were given to

state governments of the two regions, the Flemish region and the Wallonia region. The state governments were not subordinate to the central government, giving them a degree of autonomy.

3. Separate Government for Brussels: The capital city of Brussels had a separate government in which both communities had equal representation. The French-speaking people accepted equal representation in Brussels because the Dutch-speaking people had accepted equal representation in the central government.

4. Community Government: A third kind of government, called the 'community government', was created. It is elected by people belonging to one language community—Dutch, French, and German—no matter where they live. This government has the power to decide on cultural, educational, and language-related issues. This ensured that the interests of each linguistic group were protected.

- The Belgian constitution was amended four times to create a unique power-sharing model.
- It mandated equal ministers for Dutch and French speakers in the central government.
- Powers were devolved to state governments, making them independent of the central government.
- A 'Community Government' was established to handle cultural and language-related issues for each linguistic group.

The Story of Sri Lanka: Majoritarianism

Sri Lanka emerged as an independent country in 1948. The country's population is diverse, with the major social groups being the Sinhala speakers (74

The Majoritarian Policies:

1. Sinhala as the Official Language: In 1956, an Act was passed to recognise Sinhala as the only official language, thereby disregarding Tamil. This was a clear move to marginalize the Tamil-speaking population.

2. Preferential Policies: The governments followed preferential policies that favoured Sinhala applicants for university positions and government jobs, discriminating against Tamils.

3. State Protection of Buddhism: A new constitution stipulated that the state shall

protect and foster Buddhism, the religion of the Sinhala community. This further alienated the Tamil-speaking population, many of whom were Hindus or Muslims.

All these government measures, coming one after the other, gradually increased the feeling of alienation among the Sri Lankan Tamils. They felt that the constitution and government policies denied them equal political rights, discriminated against them, and ignored their interests. The distrust between the two communities turned into widespread conflict, which soon turned into a brutal civil war. This civil war caused a terrible setback to the social, cultural, and economic life of the country.

- Sri Lanka's major communities are Sinhala (74
- The government adopted majoritarian policies to establish Sinhala supremacy.
- A 1956 Act made Sinhala the sole official language, and the government favoured Sinhala applicants for jobs.
- These policies led to widespread alienation, distrust, and a devastating civil war.

Why is Power Sharing Desirable?

The stories of Belgium and Sri Lanka make us think about the importance of power sharing. There are two different sets of reasons why power sharing is desirable. These are often called prudential and moral reasons.

1. Prudential Reasons: Prudential reasons are based on a careful calculation of gains and losses. Power sharing is good because it helps to reduce the possibility of conflict between social groups. Since social conflict often leads to violence and political instability, power sharing is a good way to ensure the stability of a political order. Imposing the will of the majority community over others may look like an attractive option in the short run, but in the long run, it undermines the unity of the nation.

2. Moral Reasons: Moral reasons are based on the intrinsic value of power sharing. Power sharing is the very spirit of democracy. A democratic rule involves sharing power with those who are affected by its exercise and who have to live with its effects. People have a right to be consulted on how they are to be governed. A legitimate government is one where citizens, through participation, acquire a stake in the system.

- Prudential reasons: Power sharing helps prevent social conflict and ensures political

stability.

- Moral reasons: Power sharing is the fundamental essence of democracy and gives legitimacy to the government.

Forms of Power Sharing in Modern Democracies

The idea of power sharing has emerged in opposition to the notions of undivided political power. For a long time, it was believed that all power of a government must reside in one person or a group of persons located at one place. However, the basic principle of democracy is that people are the source of all political power. In a good democracy, due respect is given to diverse groups and views that exist in a society. Everyone has a voice in the shaping of public policies. Therefore, it follows that in a democracy, political power should be distributed as widely as possible. In modern democracies, power sharing can take many forms.

1. Horizontal Distribution of Power: This is a system where power is shared among different organs of government, such as the legislature, executive, and judiciary. This is called a horizontal distribution of power because it allows different organs of government placed at the same level to exercise different powers. It ensures that no single organ can exercise unlimited power. Each organ checks the others. This arrangement is also called a system of checks and balances.

2. Vertical Distribution of Power: This is a system where power is shared among governments at different levels. This includes a general government for the entire country and governments at the provincial or regional level. Such a general government for the entire country is called the central or Union government, and the governments at the provincial or regional level are called state governments. This is known as the vertical division of power, which is a federal form of government.

3. Power Sharing among Different Social Groups: Power can also be shared among different social groups, such as religious and linguistic groups. The 'community government' in Belgium is a good example of this arrangement. In some countries, there are constitutional and legal arrangements whereby socially weaker sections and women are represented in the legislatures and administration. This method is used to give a fair share of power to minority communities. In India, for example, we have reserved constituencies for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes.

4. Power Sharing among Political Parties, Pressure Groups, and Movements: In a democracy, power is shared among different political parties that compete for power. In the long run, power is shared among different political parties that represent different ideologies and social groups. When an alliance of two or more parties forms a coalition government, they share power. In a democracy, various pressure groups and movements also indirectly influence government decisions. They act as a check on the government and give voice to the interests of specific sections of society, such as industrialists, farmers, and traders.

- **Horizontal:** Power is shared among the legislature, executive, and judiciary (checks and balances).
- **Vertical:** Power is shared among different levels of government (Union, State, Local).
- **Social Groups:** Power is shared among religious and linguistic groups (e.g., Belgium's community government).
- **Political Parties:** Power is shared through competition, coalition governments, and the influence of pressure groups.

